

3 Game Design Principles and Examples

One game design principle that we have talked about is designing your game around one core mechanic. This can help with keeping your game more focused and engaging. An example of this is Doodle Jump, where the main mechanic is tilting your screen to move.

Another principle that I think is one of the most important is providing rewards/feedback to the player¹. Players like to be rewarded and will be motivated to keep playing the game. Almost all games include this feature, but a good example is Elden Ring, where defeating bosses feels very satisfying and gives you better weapons and items.

A third principle that can make your game even better is effective sound design². This includes sound effects and music, which can make your game even more engaging and fun to play. The Last of Us is a good example and uses sound to create very immersive atmospheres that heighten emotions.

Pros and Cons of These Principles

The pros of designing your game around one core mechanic include making the game very easy to pick up and learn for newer players while still allowing for challenging gameplay, helps keep the game more focused and coherent, and usually easier to develop and balance. Cons include that the game could feel repetitive, it might be harder to expand, and may appeal to less people.

Pros for providing rewards and feedback include making the game more satisfying and enjoyable to play, helps you communicate to the player what is “good” or “bad”, and keeps the player motivated. Cons could include relying too much on rewards which lessen their effect and could worsen the game’s balance, and punishing feedback could frustrate the player.

Effective sound design can greatly improve the game’s atmosphere and immersion for the player, can be used to also influence and give the player feedback, and can make the game more memorable. Bad sound design can lead to sensory overload for the player, which could make the game less enjoyable, and it can be hard to find the right balance.

How I Might Use These Principles

Since I do not have a lot of time to create my game, designing it around one core mechanic will help me keep it simpler and more achievable. As of now, I am thinking of making a simple racing game, and I plan to design my game around a single core mechanic, such as dodging obstacles while driving.

I also plan to include rewards and feedback in my game, like as having a points/scoring system for how far you get and how many obstacles you dodge, as well as using visual effects for winning or dodging an obstacle. This will make the game more appealing by being more engaging and enjoyable.

Lastly, I want to use sound design in my game to make it even more responsive and to create a more immersive experience. I plan to include some background music while driving and simple sound effects for certain actions, such as dodging or hitting an obstacle, or reaching a checkpoint.

Sources:

¹ <https://mainleaf.com/game-design-principles/>

² <https://www.juegostudio.com/blog/game-design-principles-every-game-designer-should-know>